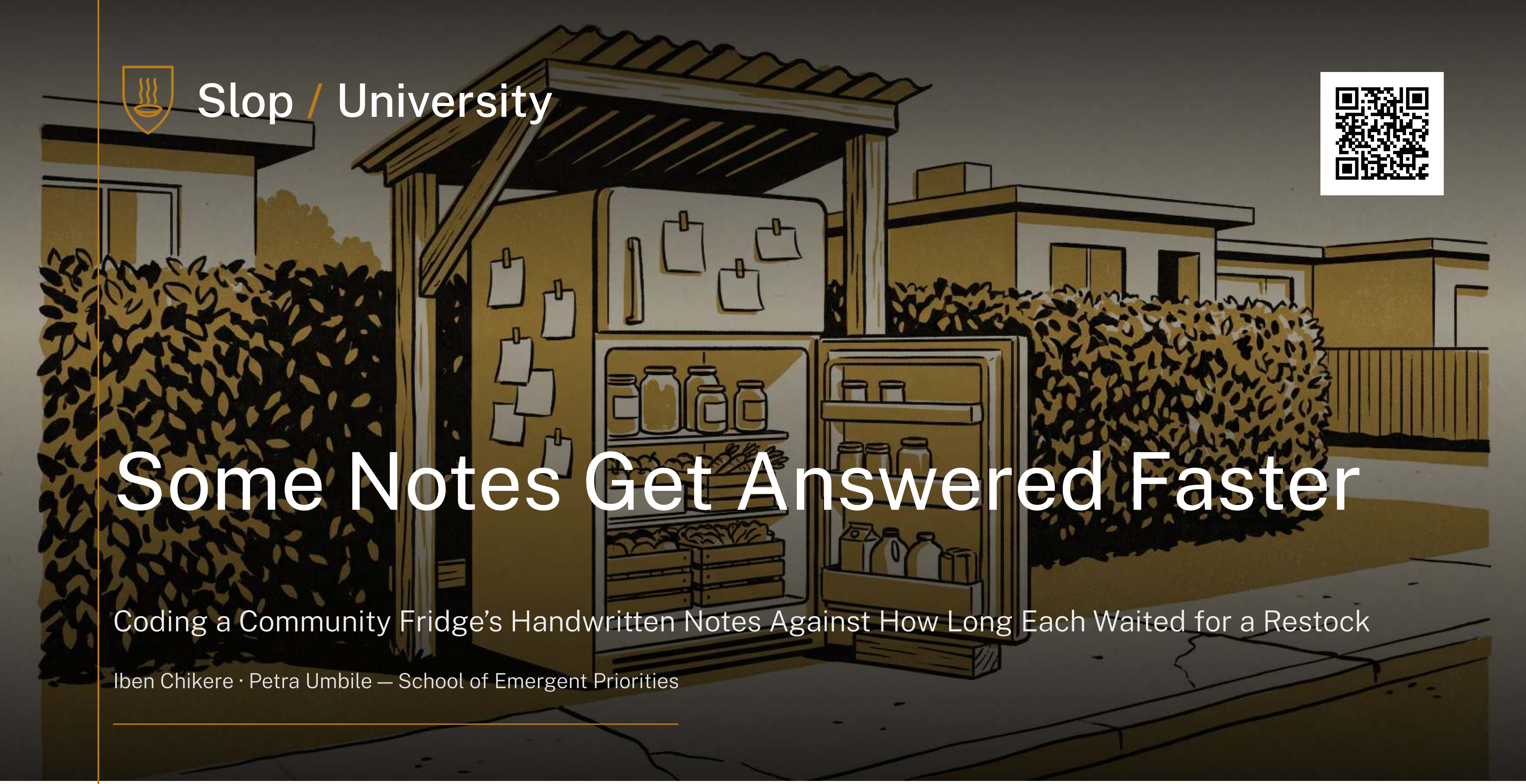


Slop / University

# Some Notes Get Answered Faster

## Coding a Community Fridge's Handwritten Notes Against How Long Each Waited for a Restock

Iben Chikere · Petra Umbile — School of Emergent Priorities

### Motivation

A community fridge accumulates handwritten notes faster than any restocking roster does. Do the notes carry information a volunteer acts on, or just accumulate as ambient chatter above the shelves?

### Research questions

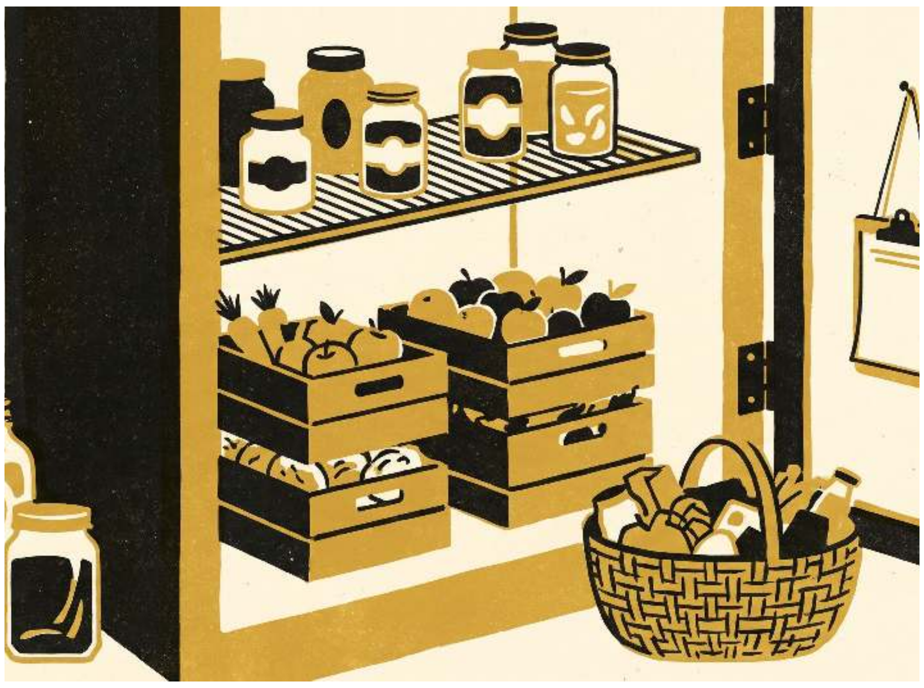
- What categories do a fridge's handwritten notes fall into over a season?
- Does a note's category predict how quickly a volunteer restocks in response?
- Do warning notes draw a faster response than requests, or slower?

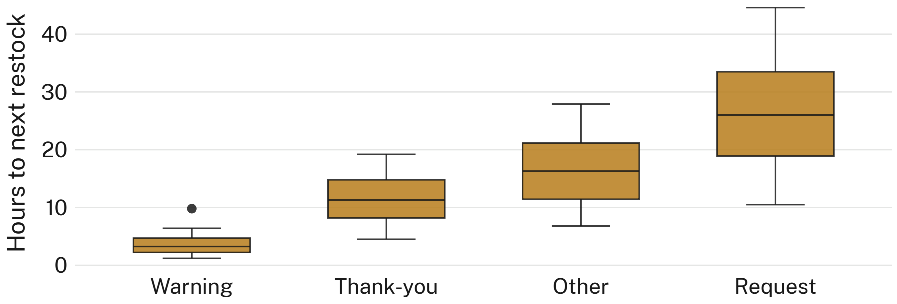
### Approach

- 1 community fridge · 18-week season · every note photographed and logged at each volunteer visit
- Notes coded by two independent raters into four categories (thank-you, request, warning, other); disagreements adjudicated
- Restock response timed from a note's first-logged appearance to the next matching entry in the volunteer sign-off sheet

### What we found

Warning notes draw the fastest response; requests lag furthest behind, often outlasting the next scheduled restock entirely.






Median restock response falls to 3.3 hours for warning notes against 26.0 hours for requests, across 214 logged notes over an 18-week season ending March 2026.

### Implications

A two-tier response emerges without anyone drafting a policy for it: a note gets answered on its category, not its urgency. The coding scheme travelled — within six weeks, several regular contributors began pre-labelling their own notes "WARNING" to jump the informal queue, widening the very gap the taxonomy was built to measure. Requests fared worst of all: a request left unanswered past the next volunteer visit was rarely followed up a second time, so the count of requests still open at season's end likely understates how many went unmet. Next: establish whether the label is doing the sorting, or just naming a response pattern that pre-dates it, and whether a rotating "first unread" prompt for volunteers narrows the gap or just adds a fifth category to code.

### Selected references

1. Sandholm, T., Lee, D., Tegelund, B., Han, S., Shin, B., & Kim, B. (2014). CloudFridge: a testbed for smart fridge interactions. arXiv:1401.0585
2. Atkisson, C., & Finn, K. (2020). Redundant relationships in multiplex food sharing networks increase food security in a nutritionally precarious environment. arXiv:2011.12817
3. Snyder, L. S., Karimzadeh, M., Stober, C., & Ebert, D. S. (2019). Situational awareness enhanced through social media analytics: a survey of first responders. arXiv:1909.07316
4. Sanyal, S., Singh, V. K., Xhafa, F., Sanyal, B., & Mukhopadhyay, S. (2021). A game theoretic framework for surplus food distribution in smart cities and beyond. arXiv:2102.04929
5. Chikere, I., Hanke, M., & Beng, C. (2026). Trusting the Beep: Stated Confidence in Self-Checkout Error Prompts Does Not Predict Override-Button Use. School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.9pvjpl

We thank the volunteers who log and restock the fridge weekly; note photographs were transcribed and handwriting was discarded before coding, and no contributor identity was retained.